

Beekeeping Folklore

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What is Beekeeping folklore?

In my project, I sought to find whether beekeeping was a simple transactional process, or if there was a deeper bond between honeybees and their keepers.

The Lore of the Honey-Bee by Tickner Edwardes offers one of the earliest examinations of the cultural, historical, and scientific significance of beekeeping.

He calls honeybee societies a “divine economy” that demonstrates a perfect form of social cooperation, something human society could learn from.



Photo of Cheryl pulling out a frame of honeybee larvae, the caps are darker in color than combs with honey

“Every job you could think of... Cleaner bees... nurse bees... heater bees... foragers... funeral attendants. They all have their own jobs, and they all do it in perfect order.”

Cheryl explained the roles within the hive; she told me that they “graduate” into different responsibilities as they age. They all have their own jobs, and they all do it in perfect order.” From the moment they hatch, bees contribute to the hive, and their organization is flawless.



Photos of Cheryl and Scott with their hives

“Beekeeping is a caretaking process... you have to understand the whole hive as a being.”

To Cheryl, caring for bees isn't just about checking frames, it's about understanding the needs of a collective organism. As she gained experience, she realized how important sustainability is. She wants her hives to be strong, especially because they face so many challenges outside her control.

*photo of Cheryl's homemade honeybee products
and business logo*

“We have been in a drought almost every year... sometimes there's flowers but there's nothing in them for the bees.”

Even short-term climate shifts can harm a hive, and Cheryl believes we should be doing more to protect them. Bees pollinate a huge portion of our food, but they also offer something beyond that: a model of order, community, and balance with the natural world.





Natural World: Folklore of Beekeeping

For my fieldwork project, I chose to focus on natural world folklore, since beekeeping is deeply connected to the beliefs, observations, and traditional knowledge people develop about the natural environment. Looking at my interview with Cheryl through this lens helped me see how her understanding of bee behavior, seasonal patterns, drought effects, and even the way she talks to her bees reflects cultural knowledge about nature that goes beyond science. Beekeeping lore is built from lived experience and passed down through stories, practices, and personal beliefs about how we should interact with the natural world. Beekeeping is more than a transactional practice; it's building a connection to the hives as entities.

Conclusion

I learned a lot from this project, and my grandmother Cheryl has been my primary teacher. Honeybees are one of the most fascinating animals because of their inborn sense of organization and roles within the hive. Honeybees communicate, collaborate, and are extremely good at making decisions for the sake of the hive. After talking with Cheryl, I'm certain we should be learning from them in the way they sustain themselves and communicate with each other. Honeybees have always been seen as advanced for insects; some cultures even depicted them as Gods.

We should be working harder to save the honeybee population and take them as example of how we should be working as a society.

